

By **SESHADRI CHARI**

UNANIMITY ON 'BHARAT' IS KEY NOW

BY NO STRETCH OF IMAGINATION IS THE MODI GOVERNMENT THE FIRST TO USE THE NAME BHARAT INSTEAD OF INDIA



Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

By no stretch of the imagination is the Modi government the first to use the name Bharat instead of India. The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) has been traditionally using Bharat in its narrative and ends the official prayer with the '*Bharat Mata ki Jai*' slogan. The Sarsanghchalak of the RSS, Mohan Bhagwat, recently stated that proper nouns cannot be translated and hence urged the use of Bharat "in all fields to see the change it would bring". The Modi government began using Bharat in the G20 summit and is waiting to see the change. While the world appears to have taken the change in its stride, a section of the Opposition is not too happy with it.

Even before the RSS, there have been instances of political parties, especially the Congress and others, suggesting the use of Bharat officially.

Shantaram Naik, a Congress MP from Goa, introduced a private member bill, not once but twice, in the Rajya Sabha seeking an amendment to Article 1 of the Constitution which mentions "India that is Bharat". His Bill basically sought three important changes: substituting the word India with the word Bharat in the Preamble of the Constitution, use of the word Bharat only in place of 'India that is Bharat' and thirdly, that wherever the word India appears in the Constitution, it should be replaced with Bharat. Citing the popular song *'Jahan daal daal par sone ki chidiya karti hai basera, woh Bharat desh hai mera"* for generating a sense of patriotism, the Congress MP pleaded for Bharat.

The Samajwadi Party (SP) carried the patriotic logic further and connected it with "swadeshi economic policies", rejecting Western consumerism by substituting the word India with Bharat in the Constitution. In April 2004, the SP proposed to use only 'Bharat' in the Constitution "as a step to protect the identity of the country", to "ban the import of luxury goods" and "to take other suitable economic and political measures to end the cultural degeneration being encouraged by the Western consumerist lifestyle". Whatever the logic of the BJP, it appears to pale into insignificance before the spirited defence of Bharat by the Congress and SP. Not to be outdone, BJP veteran and former Karnataka chief minister B.S. Yediyurappa suggested an amendment to the Constitution to rename India as 'Bharat', and linked the name change to Kannada pride. So, Bharat has a southern touch too.

Indologist John Muir, whose main work was *Original Sanskrit Texts on the Origin and History of the People of India, their Religion and Institutions* (1852–1870), put forward two findings. One